which his sentence of deportation was confirmed before being upgraded to a sentence of death by hanging, right to the day of his execution on 23 March 1931, are present in the hanging of the Babbar Khalsa Akalis on 27 February 1926.

Whether it be police beatings, starvation through hunger strike or death by hanging, the idea of inviting untold suffering for an exalted cause such as India's freedom was ingrained in the revolutionaries. This does not mean that individuals did not break under pressure. But when they did, they were reminded of the path they had willingly themselves chosen to tread. Thus, upon the trial for the Second Lahore Conspiracy Case being concluded in October 1930, when a judgment from the special tribunal was being anxiously awaited and Sukhdev had begun contemplating suicide, Bhagat Singh reprimanded him with the words of the Naujawan Bharat Sabha: 'to suffer and sacrifice through service'. Sukhdev expected to be sent to jail for twenty years. He did not want this. He wanted either release or death. But Bhagat Singh reminded him how '[a]t the time of our imprisonment, the condition for the political prisoners of our party was very miserable' and that 'we were not aware of the technique of forced feeding and nor had we ever thought of it', but having experienced its horrors, 'we were ready to die' and yet had emerged stronger. He told Sukhdev, 'I want to tell you that obstacles make a man perfect.' 'Neither you nor I, or any of us, have suffered any pain so far,' he said.

To know pain, he draws upon its depiction in Russian literature for its realism, reminding Sukhdev, 'You will recollect that we have talked several times about realism in the Russian literature, which is nowhere visible in our own. 'We highly appreciate the situations of pain in their stories, but we do not feel that spirit of suffering within ourselves,' he said. And yet ironically, '[w]e also admire their passion and the extraordinary height of their characters, but we never bother to find out the reason'. Russian literature has much to commend it because 'the reference to their resolve to bear pain has produced the intensity, the suffering of pain, and this has given great depth and height to their characters and literature'.[7] It is well-known that Bhagat Singh often referred to the young having something